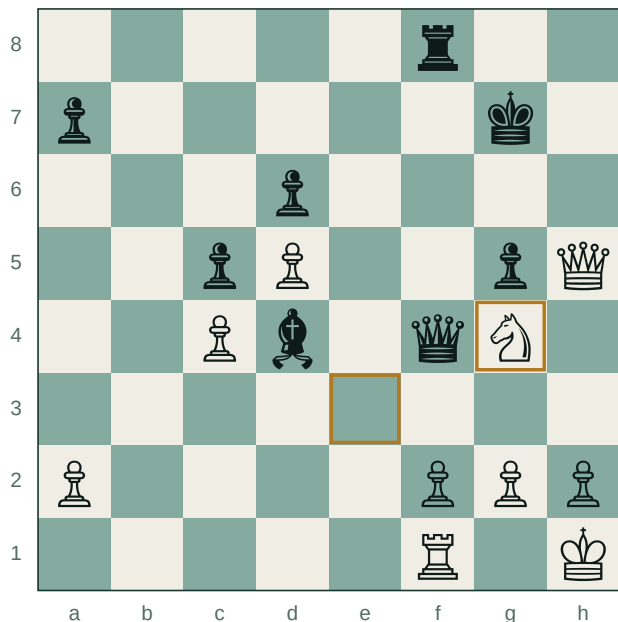


Trapping a piece: Black, move 35

Trapping a piece

Black to move



Previous move: 35.Ng4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

35...Rh8 36. Qxh8+ Kxh8

35...Rh8 The rook moves from f8 to h8. Recorded reply: **36.Qxh8+**.

36...Kxh8 The king captures the queen on h8.

At the end, nominal material is White 14 / Black 16 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +4. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +4:** the balance goes from -2 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

An attacked piece is not trapped if it can give check, trade itself favorably, or open an escape through a sacrifice.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A trapped piece lacks safe retreat squares. Winning it usually requires restricting its routes before attacking it, or forcing it into a cage.

HOW TO LOOK

Trace every plausible escape square for the target, including captures and counterchecks. Then find the move that closes the remaining route.

The defending king is on h1. Geometrically undefended: queen on h5 and rook on f1. Check for tactical protection.